

LONGWOOD AVENUE SITE VISIT NOTES
PEDESTRIAN ADVISORY COMMITTEE (PedAC)
WEDNESDAY, JUNE 28, 2017 @ 6:00 PM
CORNER OF HARVARD STREET & LONGWOOD AVENUE
BROOKLINE MA 02446
(minutes submitted by Jane Ross)

Members Present: Frank Caro, Jane Ross, Allison Pincus-Jacobs, Tracy Bare, David Trevvett

Transportation Board Liaison: Jonathan Kapust

Member Absent: Arnold Bornfriend

Overview:

This site visit consisted of a walk along Longwood Avenue to observe conditions for pedestrians. We met at the corner of Harvard Street and Longwood Avenue and walked to the Boston line at the Muddy River and back again. We were grateful for Jonathan's professional explanations of regulations and design factors.

Actions taken:

No actions were taken. This was an observational site visit. Some suggested actions are included in these notes in bullet points.

Longwood Avenue Conditions:

@ Harvard Street A police officer was directing traffic at Longwood and Harvard; he left at 6:00. We noted there is no crosswalk on the North side of the intersection. The intersection was very busy, and pedestrians were mostly crossing in the crosswalks. Cars traveling southbound on Harvard Street in a hurry to make a left turn onto Longwood may not see the pedestrian crossing. There was a steady stream of cyclists coming up Longwood from the medical area and turning right onto Harvard Street. Coming up Longwood, there was no way for cyclists to tell where the no-bike-riding-on-sidewalk restriction starts.

- Add "Yield to Pedestrian" signs
- Add "Don't Block the Box" striping on the roadway
- Make crosswalks more perpendicular

@ Sewall Avenue The crosswalk here is on a diagonal, with a Stop sign only on Sewall

- Add more lighting, especially on the South Side of Longwood
- Two small tree wells with grass could be filled with cement

@ St. Paul Street Ramps are not accessible. No audio signal. Lack of street signs for St. Paul. The crosswalk going West ends running into a pole. The only benches the entire length of Longwood Avenue are the two in front of the Housing Authority at 90 Longwood and several that are set back from the sidewalk on the south side of Longwood along the Lawrence School playground path at the end of Marshall Street.

@ Marshal Street Ramps are very steep. The crosswalks are not painted. Drains at both corners may affect the design of these crosswalks.

- Remove the stump of a town tree sticking up in front of 156 Longwood

@ Kent Street Right on Red is allowed in some directions, but none has good visibility. Sidewalk rough. The retaining wall at Longwood Towers is encroaching on the sidewalk. On entering the hospital area one might expect more accessibility features, but we did not find this to be the case.

@ Chapel Street This is a very busy intersection near the hospital district with many pedestrians who were careful to walk with the green light, but none pushed the button to get a Walk signal. It isn't possible to see the Walk signal from everywhere in the intersection.

Themes to Explore in Future Site visits:

If Walk signs sequenced in a more standardized way town-wide, pedestrians wouldn't need to figure out each intersection, such as whether to push a button or not.

Availability of audio walk signals is inconsistent

Ways to define/find/report uneven sidewalks

Some crosswalks are perpendicular, others are diagonal (which makes the crossing longer). Is there a good, well-understood rationale for these differences?

Asphalt sidewalks are the same color as the street, which can be confusing for low vision pedestrians

How to determine which ramps need to be ungraded. Some wheelchair ramps (curb cuts at intersections) lead to the 90-degree crossing, others point to the center of the intersection. Is there a good, well-understood rationale for these differences? The latter can force wheelchairs or large strollers to actually leave the crosswalks.

Tree wells – permeable pavement?

Signs alerting drivers to pedestrian crossings

Signs letting cyclists know when they need to dismount in commercial areas. Which are the "business districts" where bicycles are not allowed to be ridden on sidewalks?

Encroachments on sidewalks, including public installations (town trees including ground-level shoots, mail boxes, poles that support wires) and those on private property (low-hanging tree branches, creeping gardens, tall hedges).

The site visit was adjourned at 7:40 pm.